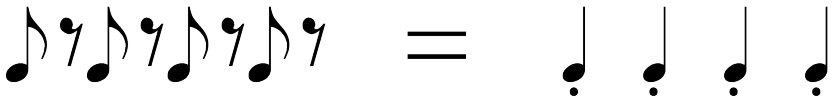
LESSON 15: STACCATO, PERCUSSION, CRESCENDO, ANACRUSIS

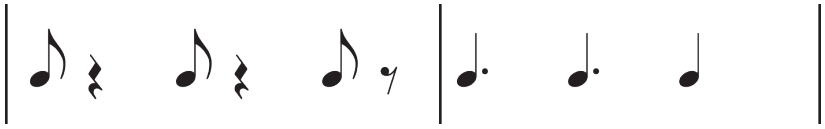
Notes that are **staccato** do not sustain, they are immediately rested. Staccato rhythms might feel “short and choppy,” and often possess an innate “sharpness” to them. This is the opposite of **legato** rhythms, where notes sustain into one another to create “long and flowing” passages.

To indicate that a note or strum should be played staccato, we simply place a dot above or below it. This can be used to “clean up” rhythms that might look busy or confusing when written using rest symbols. For example, these two rhythms are *essentially* the same, but the version on the right is much easier to read.



Percussive Notation

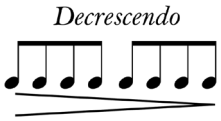
Many percussive instruments (like the clave or woodblock) naturally produce staccato notes and can not sustain a pitch or sound. Therefore, the use of rest signs or dots is unnecessary and are only used when they can aide in making the rhythm easier to read. For example, the two rhythms below are identical, but the one on the left is a bit cluttered. You needn’t write rhythms like that when you’re only conveying rhythmic information!



Crescendo and Decrescendo

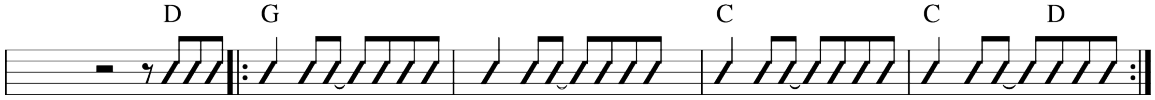
To **crescendo** means to grow louder. This is easily done by strumming just a few strings softly and then gradually increasing how many strings you’re hitting and how hard your pick strikes them. You can also create a crescendo effect by palm muting your strums, then sliding your palm mute back toward the bridge slowly to “open up” the sound and reduce the muting effect.

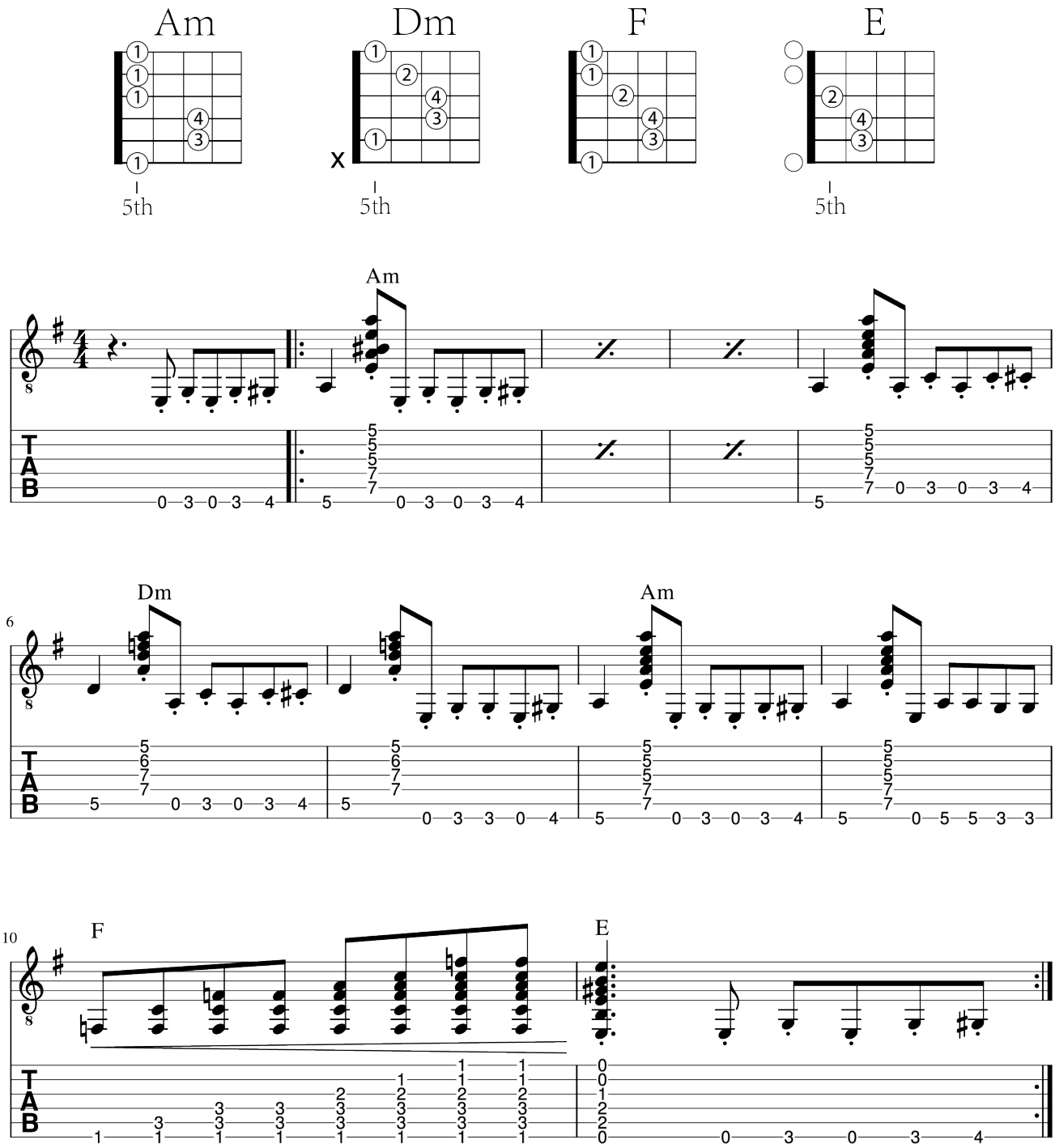
To **decrescendo** means the opposite — you’ll gradually get quieter.



Anacrusis (Pick-up Notes)

Sometimes, rhythms begin *before* the 1 beat of a song or piece. Those are called **pickup notes**, and the entire phrase is called an **anacrusis**. Below is a simple example using chords.



Exercise (Video #14.1)

Pay close attention to which notes are performed staccato and which ones should be sustained. All chords (except E) will be played as barre chords. The index finger will be used for the individual notes in between chords.